

Email Deliverability and Inbox Placement Handbook

Study notes for email campaign operations

1. Delivery versus deliverability

Delivery means the receiving server accepted the message. Deliverability is about where the accepted message ends up: the inbox, a promotions or other tab, or the spam folder. A campaign can show a 99 percent delivery rate and still have poor inbox placement, because accepted mail can be filtered into spam. Inbox placement rate is the share of sent messages that reach the inbox.

2. Sender reputation

Mailbox providers (ISPs) keep a reputation score for the sending domain and for the sending IP address. Reputation is built from how recipients treat your mail and how well you follow sending rules.

- **Positive signals:** opens, replies, clicks, messages moved from spam to inbox, messages added to contacts.
- **Negative signals:** spam complaints, deletes without reading, high bounce rates, sending to spam traps, sudden volume spikes, failing authentication.

Domain reputation follows the brand across IP addresses, so changing IPs does not fix a poor domain reputation. IP reputation matters most for new IPs and for shared IP pools, where other senders on the same IP can affect you.

3. Why emails go to spam

- Missing or failing SPF, DKIM or DMARC authentication.
- High spam complaint rate, often caused by unwanted mail or a hidden unsubscribe link.
- Poor list quality: purchased or old lists, invalid addresses, and spam traps.
- High bounce rates, especially hard bounces to addresses that do not exist.
- A new IP or domain sending a large volume without warm-up.
- Spammy content: misleading subject lines, all capital letters, too many links or images, URL shorteners and broken HTML.
- Low engagement: when many recipients ignore or delete the mail, ISPs learn to filter it.
- Shared IP or domain blocklisting.

4. IP warm-up and using multiple IPs

A new IP address has no reputation, so ISPs treat it with caution. Warm-up means starting with a small daily volume sent to the most engaged recipients and increasing the volume gradually over several weeks while watching bounces, complaints and placement. Skipping warm-up is a common cause of throttling and spam placement.

Large senders use multiple IPs to split traffic, for example by campaign type (promotional versus transactional), by sending domain or by ISP. Using more than one IP lowers the risk that a problem on one stream damages everything and makes troubleshooting easier, because each IP and domain pair can be monitored on its own. Each IP needs its own warm-up, reverse DNS (PTR) record and consistent sending pattern.

5. Bounces and complaints

Type	Meaning	Action
Hard bounce	Permanent failure, for example the mailbox does not exist or the domain is invalid	Remove the address immediately
Soft bounce	Temporary failure, for example mailbox full or server busy	Retry for a limited time, then suppress if it keeps failing
Block bounce	The ISP rejected the mail because of reputation, IP or content	Check blocklists, authentication and the rejection code, then slow down

Bounce rate is the number of bounced emails divided by the number of emails sent, multiplied by 100. A healthy list normally stays well under 2 percent bounce rate. The complaint rate is the number of spam complaints divided by delivered emails; senders should aim to keep it far below 0.1 percent.

6. What to do when emails start landing in spam

- Check authentication first: confirm SPF, DKIM and DMARC pass and are aligned for the affected domain.
- Check blocklists for the sending IPs and domains and review any ISP rejection codes in the logs.
- Look at the data per ISP: if only one ISP is affected, the cause is usually reputation or throttling with that ISP.
- Reduce volume and send only to recently engaged recipients (for example people who opened or clicked in the last 30 to 60 days).
- Clean the list: remove hard bounces, inactive recipients and suspected spam traps.
- Review the content, subject line and links, and make sure a visible one-click unsubscribe is present.
- Run seed tests or use postmaster tools to check inbox placement, then rebuild volume gradually.
- Consider rotating to a warmed-up IP or a separate sending domain for the affected stream, but only after fixing the root cause.

7. Monitoring tools

Operations teams watch their own monitoring application and ISP tools together: Google Postmaster Tools for Gmail domain and spam rate, Microsoft SNDS and JMRP for Outlook, Yahoo's complaint feedback loop, blocklist checkers, and DNS validation tools to confirm authentication records. Daily review of delivery, bounce, complaint and inbox placement per ISP, domain and IP is the best way to catch problems early.